DO YOU KNOW?

Sound travels about 5 times faster in water than in air. Since the speed of sound in sea water is very large (being about 1530 m s^{-1} which is more than 5500 km/h^{-1}), two whales in the sea which are even hundreds of kilometres away can talk to each other very easily through the sea water.

8.6 Reflection of Sound

Sound bounces off a surface of solid or a liquid medium like a rubber ball that bounces off from a wall. An obstacle of large size which may be polished or rough is needed for the reflection of sound waves. The laws of reflection are:

- The angle in which the sound is incident is equal to the angle in which it is reflected.
- Direction of incident sound, the reflected sound and the normal are in the same plane.

8.6.1 Uses of multiple reflections of sound

Musical instruments

Megaphones, loud speakers, horns, musical instruments such as nathaswaram, shehnai and trumpets are all designed to send sound in a particular direction without spreading it in all directions. In these instruments, a tube followed by a conical opening reflects sound successively to guide most of the sound waves from the source in the forward direction towards the audience.



Figure 8.7 Megaphone or horn

Stethoscope

Stethoscope is a medical instrument used for listening to sounds produced in the body. In stethoscopes, these sounds reach doctor's ears by multiple reflections that happen in the connecting tube.

More to Know



Use of ear phones for long hours can cause infection in the inner parts of the ears, apart from damage to the ear drum. Your safety is in danger if you wear ear phones while crossing signals, walking on the roads and travelling. Using earphones while sleeping is all the more dangerous as current is passing in the wires. It may even lead to mental irritation. Hence, you are advised to deter from using earphones as far as possible.

8.7 Echo

When we shout or clap near a suitable reflecting surface such as a tall building or a mountain, we will hear the same sound again a little later. This sound which we hear is called an echo. The sensation of sound persists in our brain for about 0.1s.

Hence, to hear a distinct echo the time interval between the original sound and the reflected sound must be at least 0.1s. Let us consider the speed of sound to be 340 m s^{-1} at 25° C. The sound must go to the obstacle and return to the ear of the listener on reflection after 0.1 s. The total distance covered by the sound from the point of generation to the reflecting surface and back should be at least 340 m s^{-1} × 0.1 s = 34 m.

Thus, for hearing distinct echoes, the minimum distance of the obstacle from the source of sound must be half of this distance i.e. 17 m. This distance will change with the temperature of air. Echoes may be heard more than once due to successive or multiple

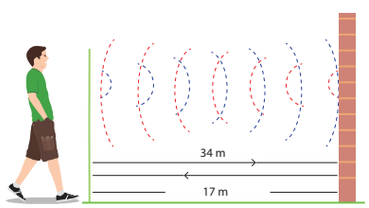


Figure 8.8 Echo

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